

MARGARITAS ANTE PORCOS*

How to not sell books in airports—Mineral water in the desert—How to denigrate other people's ideas and succeed at it

Let me start again. *The Black Swan* is about consequential epistemic limitations, both psychological (hubris and biases) and philosophical (mathematical) limits to knowledge, both individual and collective. I say “consequential” because the focus is on impactful rare events, as our knowledge, both empirical and theoretical, breaks down with those—the more remote the events, the less we can forecast them, yet they are the most impactful. So *The Black Swan* is about human error in some domains, swelled by a long tradition of scientism and a plethora of information that fuels confidence without increasing knowledge. It covers the expert problem—harm caused by reliance on scientific-looking charlatans, with or without equations, or regular noncharlatanic scientists with a bit more confidence about their methods than the evidence warrants. The focus is in not being the turkey in places where it matters, though there is nothing wrong in being a fool where that has no effect.

MAIN ERRORS IN UNDERSTANDING THE MESSAGE

I will briefly state some of the difficulties in understanding the message and the ideas of this book, typically perpetrated by professionals, though, surprisingly, less by the casual reader, the amateur, my friend. Here is a list.

1) Mistaking the Black Swan (capitalized) for the logical problem. (Mistake made by U.K. intellectuals—intellectuals in other countries do not know enough analytical philosophy to make that mistake.)*

2) Saying the maps we had were better than having no maps. (People who do not have experience in cartography, risk “experts,” or worse, employees of the Federal Reserve Bank of the United States.)

This is the strangest of errors. I know few people who would board a plane heading for La Guardia airport in New York City with a pilot who was using a map of Atlanta's airport “because there is nothing else.” People with a functioning brain would rather drive, take the train, or stay